

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Daniel 1:1

Prior to this siege, Jehoiakim (609–598 BC) had been a vassal of Egypt; his reign in Judah was exceedingly wicked ([2 Kgs 23:36–24:6](#); [2 Chr 36:5–8](#); [Jer 25](#)). The exile and captivity of Daniel and his friends in 605 BC prefigure the exile of the rest of the nation in 597 and 586 BC (see [2 Kgs 24:1–25:21](#)). The Lord employed King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon as his unwitting servant to accomplish his ends (cp. [Jer 25:9](#); [27:6](#)).

Daniel 1:1–2

These verses explain how it was that Daniel and his friends were in Babylon and succinctly give the setting in which Daniel lived during the years of exile.

Daniel 1:1–21

God fulfilled his prophetic word by sending his rebellious people into exile (see [Jer 25:11–12](#); [29:10](#)). God also extended his grace to a remnant in exile, and he protected and prospered Daniel and three other young Hebrew captives. These young men received the best training of the time in the Babylonian king's court and were thus well equipped to be God's witnesses in Babylon. They made the God of Israel known even in exile.

Daniel 1:1–6.28

The first half of Daniel, in describing the experiences and wisdom of Daniel and his three Hebrew friends, demonstrates that God is the ruler of the world and that God's people need to be faithful and live and act wisely in every situation in which they find themselves.

Daniel 1:2

The Lord, who is sovereign over history, gave the victory to Nebuchadnezzar; it was not accomplished by the king's might or the power of

his god Marduk, the high god of the Babylonian pantheon. The Lord used the Exile to judge and discipline his people, as had been threatened in the Law (e.g., [Deut 28:64](#)) and by the prophets (e.g., [Jer 25:8–14](#)). • The sacred objects had been dedicated and set aside for use in the Temple of God built by Solomon. After spending nearly seventy years in the treasure-house of Marduk, these vessels were further defiled by Belshazzar in 539 BC ([Dan 5:1–4](#)); they were later returned to the rebuilt Temple in Ezra's time ([Ezra 1:7–11](#); [5:13–16](#)). • the land of Babylonia: Israel's rebellion led them back to where rebellious humanity had constructed the Tower of Babel ([Gen 11:2](#)).

Daniel 1:3

staff: Though often translated “eunuchs” (cp. [Isa 39:7](#)), in this case the Hebrew term (saris) likely means that Ashpenaz and those under his authority were high government officials (see [2 Kgs 8:6](#)).

Daniel 1:3–7

The Lord fulfilled his threat to make sons of the royal family serve in Babylon ([Isa 39:7](#)) despite their being heirs to the promises of Davidic kingship. Nebuchadnezzar made a powerful attempt to proselytize them by education, social and religious pressure, and name changes. Instead, their impact upon their pagan surroundings became the outstanding feature of their stay at the king's palace and court.

Daniel 1:4

strong, healthy: They had no defect or blemish that would disqualify them; the Lord had the same requirements for Israel's priests ([Lev 21:16–24](#); [22:17–25](#)). These youths had the wisdom, knowledge, understanding, and character needed to function at the highest levels of government. • The literature of Babylon was immense and included wisdom and esoteric literature, creation stories, magic incantations, theogonies (origins and genealogies of the gods), legal corpora, ancient histories, letters, dream journals, vision manuals, and mathematical and astrological materials. The

education of these young men—all in a foreign language—rivalled that of Moses in Egypt.

Daniel 1:5

The king attempted to create a bond of dependence, gratitude, and loyalty by giving them food and wine from his own kitchens.

Daniel 1:6–7

Their new Babylonian names were to help enculturate the Hebrews into the pagan Babylonian society. Daniel (“God is my Judge” or “God has judged”) became Belteshazzar (“Bel [a Babylonian god] protects his life”). Hananiah (“the Lord is grace”) became Shadrach (possibly meaning “command of Aku,” another Babylonian god). Mishael (“who is God?”) became Meshach (“who is Aku?”). Azariah (“the Lord helps”) became Abednego (“servant of Nego/Nebo,” another Babylonian god).

Daniel 1:8

Daniel was determined not to defile himself: The meat and wine from Nebuchadnezzar’s table were probably unclean by Jewish standards. The Babylonians used unclean meats such as pork (see [Lev 11:1–23](#); [Deut 14:1–21](#)), and their meat and wine had probably been dedicated to Babylonian gods. The other young Hebrews agreed with Daniel ([Dan 1:12–16](#)). They trusted God and obeyed his commands, and God blessed them (cp. [Deut 28:1–14](#)).

Daniel 1:8–14

Daniel determined not to defile himself with the king’s food and wine or to yield his religious and moral independence to the king. He gave God the opportunity to demonstrate his loving kindness and care toward his trustworthy servants. This strong reliance upon God by Daniel and his friends is a significant motif throughout the book (see also [2:16–23](#); [3:16–18](#); [6:16](#)).

Daniel 1:9

God worked on Daniel’s behalf by influencing Ashpenaz’s attitude (cp. [Exod 11:3](#)).

Daniel 1:10

Ashpenaz was understandably afraid of the king.

Daniel 1:11–13

Daniel found a wise solution that would protect his spiritual integrity and Ashpenaz’s head.

Daniel 1:12

vegetables and water: Such a diet would steer clear of offensive foods ([1:8](#)) and, as a kind of fast, would demonstrate mourning over their exile in a foreign land.

Daniel 1:13–14

make your decision: Daniel’s exemplary wisdom, prudence, and courtesy are seen in his respectful stance toward his attendant, who responded favorably.

Daniel 1:15–21

In their training, Daniel and his friends completed a tough curriculum in the context of the most threatening pagan culture of the day, yet they remained faithful to the Lord. As they mastered language, literature, and science, they pursued excellence and honored God, who added many gifts to their skills and learning.

Daniel 1:17

All four young men were outstanding students. God gave Daniel the special ability to interpret . . . visions and dreams, which were often prophetic (cp. Joseph, [Gen 37:5–11](#)).

Daniel 1:19

The king talked with all the young men who were trained, not just Daniel and his three friends. This was a thorough oral examination and discussion of things that were most important to the king. God arranged for the four young men to be his witnesses among the nations, and they were greatly honored by being appointed to positions of power, responsibility, and opportunity (cp. [Gen 41:37-40](#); [45:5](#); [Exod 2:1-10](#)).

Daniel 1:20

The magicians were a class of soothsayer priests who could also interpret dreams (cp. [Gen 44:1-15](#)) and do wonders (cp. [Exod 7:11](#)). The term enchanter (Hebrew 'ashap), found only in Daniel, comes from an Akkadian term for people who uttered spells.

Daniel 1:21

the first year of the reign of King Cyrus: Cyrus the Great ruled over Persia (559–530 BC), Media (from 549 BC), and Babylon (from 539 BC). He thus created the Persian Empire (539–331 BC; see study notes on 5:30, 31; cp. [Isa 45:1-2](#)).

Daniel 2:1

second year: If the three-year training period for Daniel and his friends is understood as having occurred in parts of three calendar years, it could have been completed by this time (cp. [2:48](#)).

Daniel 2:1-3

Nebuchadnezzar's dream disturbed him so much that he called on his specially trained advisers to help him.

Daniel 2:1-49

God gave a dream that encompassed the flow of world history over the centuries, and Daniel interpreted the enigmatic imagery of this revelation. This dream and its interpretation reflect a key theme of the book—the assured final

establishment of the Kingdom of God as the ultimate goal of history ([2:44-45](#); [7:9-14](#), [26-27](#)). This chapter also demonstrates the inability of paganism to discern the activity and plans of Israel's God.

Daniel 2:1-6.28

This section contains stories and dreams from the experiences of Daniel and his friends in Babylon. Daniel exercised his special gift of understanding the meaning of dreams and his mastery of literature and science ([1:17](#)). Chapter 2 gives a broad schematic view of all history until the appearance of God's kingdom ([2:44-49](#)). Chapters [3-6](#) portray the demise of Babylon and the rise of Persia. History moves toward its inexorable goal—the everlasting Kingdom of God ([2:44](#); [4:2-3](#), [34](#); [6:26](#)).

Daniel 2:2

magicians, enchanter: See study note on 1:20. • Sorcerers were incantation priests or ritual technicians. • Astrologers studied the heavenly bodies to discern the times and seasons of major events.

Daniel 2:3

a dream that deeply troubles me: The king had reason to fear that his throne might be in danger from other groups.

Daniel 2:4

Aramaic had been established by the Assyrians as the lingua franca of international communication. The practice was continued by the Babylonians. • Tell us the dream: The Babylonian wise men needed to know the contents of the dream in order to look them up in reference books. They did not depend on divine revelation.

Daniel 2:9

Only someone with supernatural insight could tell Nebuchadnezzar the contents of his dream (cp. [Mark 2:9-12](#)).

Daniel 2:10–11

The Babylonian wise men could possibly interpret dreams, but they could not retell them without being told, and they recognized that such a thing was only possible for divinity (cp. [2:17–23](#), [27–28](#)).

Daniel 2:12

The king was furious because contradicting or refusing the king's command was an offense punishable by death. The king was supposed to be treated as divine, so they were violating protocol in saying that he was not. The king's sages were also supposed to have a connection with the divine, but they admitted that they did not. The offense to the king was so severe that he ordered that all the wise men of Babylon be executed. The king's rage foreshadows [11:11–35](#).

Daniel 2:16

The fact that Daniel could go at once to see the king shows his authority and influence. Daniel demonstrated his wisdom and excellent protocol at the royal court by using gentle words to turn away anger (cp. [Prov 15:1](#)).

Daniel 2:17–23

With faith and wisdom, Daniel prayed for God's intervention (cp. [Phil 4:6](#)). When God answered his prayer, Daniel praised God for giving him wisdom and knowledge ([Dan 2:20–21](#)). The God of heaven produced the dream and its meaning, demonstrating his supremacy over all other gods, including the gods of Babylon.

Daniel 2:18

Daniel appealed to God's mercy (see [Exod 34:6–7](#)). God was not obligated to answer Daniel's prayer, but doing so would accord with his character.

Daniel 2:20–23

Daniel acknowledged and praised Israel's God (God of my ancestors, [2:23](#)) as the source of the dream and its interpretation.

Daniel 2:21

The dream revealed the Lord as the sovereign king of history (see [2:29–45](#)).

Daniel 2:24

Daniel's influence with Arioch indicates Daniel's wisdom and stature in the royal service.

Daniel 2:25

There were captives in Babylon from other nations besides Judah. • Daniel, one of Abraham's offspring, brought the blessing of God's revelation to the Babylonian king (see [Gen 12:3](#)).

Daniel 2:26

Is this true? Nebuchadnezzar was surprised that a non-Babylonian could have this ability since the Babylonian religion and culture strongly emphasized their own wise men as "purveyors of the heavens."

Daniel 2:27–28

Daniel made it clear that no human could do what was required (cp. [2:10–11](#); see also [Gen 41:16](#)).

Daniel 2:28

a God in heaven: Daniel proclaimed one true God who rules all things ([2:20–21](#)), not a limited local deity such as the ones the Babylonians worshiped. The God of Daniel's ancestors ([2:23](#)) is the God in heaven who reveals secrets. The Babylonian gods could not do this. • what will happen: In the ancient world, dreams were often understood as revealing the future.

Daniel 2:29–30

God had shown the king the long march of future history. Nebuchadnezzar was keenly interested in history, pursuing knowledge of the past and seeking to make a place for himself as history went forward. God wanted Nebuchadnezzar to understand the course of history, perhaps to impress upon him that Israel's God, the God of heaven, is the God of all history.

Daniel 2:31–33

The progression downward is one of value: from the most valuable, gold ([2:32](#)), to the least valuable, iron and baked clay ([2:33](#)).

Daniel 2:32–33

There were gradations of gold; fine gold was the highest quality. • thighs: Above the knees. • legs: Below the knees.

Daniel 2:34

The phrase from a mountain is implied (cp. [2:35](#)) but is not in the Aramaic text.

Daniel 2:35

covered (literally *filled*) the whole earth: Cp. [Gen 1:28](#); [Exod 1:7](#); [Matt 28:18–20](#). This new kingdom would replace all other kingdoms.

Daniel 2:36–38

you are the greatest of kings (literally *king of kings*): Nebuchadnezzar had attained kingship over all other empires and their kings. He was the appointed ruler for that time in history ([Jer 25:8–9](#)).

Daniel 2:39

inferior to yours: Silver was inferior in value to gold, as the chest is lower than the head. Nebuchadnezzar was an extremely stable ruler who held the Neo-Babylonian Empire together.

Persia, by contrast, was often threatened with internal divisions and instability around the periphery.

Daniel 2:41–42

as weak as clay: Feet are crucial to stability; the feet were brittle and illustrate how precarious the whole image—that is, earthly kingdoms and their power—would be.

Daniel 2:43

Just as iron and clay do not mix, . . . intermarriage among different people groups could weaken political alliances rather than produce real or lasting unity. This empire would be fragmented.

Daniel 2:44

Those kings were probably kings that arose within the fourth kingdom and attempted to strengthen themselves by alliances of intermarriage. However, the phrase might refer to all the kings of the statue as God's kingdom persistently breaks into the flow of history. • it will stand forever: Only a kingdom whose authority and power are from God (see [John 18:36](#)) can never be destroyed, for all earthly kingdoms crumble.

Daniel 2:45

The Babylonians often pictured the earth as a mountain (or ziggurat); hence, the rock would cover or replace the entire earth. • The dream is true: The dream, clearly explained by divine revelation, was truth from God. • its meaning is certain: God guaranteed that what the dream communicated would certainly take place.

Daniel 2:46

The Aramaic word translated worshiped could also be translated “paid him homage or honor,” but not necessarily so. Nebuchadnezzar was a pagan; his religion had many gods, and he thought that the spirit of the gods was in Daniel ([4:8](#); cp. [5:11](#)). Regardless, he was recognizing that what Daniel

had done was not the result of the ordinary human spirit (cp. [Gen 41:38](#)).

Daniel 2:47

greatest of gods . . . Lord over kings: Nebuchadnezzar repaid the compliment ([2:37-38](#)), acknowledging by his words and actions ([2:46](#)) that God is supreme over all, even over Nebuchadnezzar himself.

Daniel 2:48

Daniel was made ruler over Babylon as the king's deputy (cp. [Gen 41:37-46](#)).

Daniel 2:49

Daniel delegated the administration of the province to his three friends so that he could remain in the king's court as his counselor.

Daniel 3:1

The plain of Dura might be the plain adjacent to the city of Babylon, or the Aramaic term might refer to the magnificent outer wall of Babylon described by the Greek historian Herodotus. • statue: Literally *image*.

Daniel 3:1-30

Nebuchadnezzar's megalomania, perhaps encouraged by the vision of ch [2](#), inspired him to construct a gilded statue and demand that everyone in his empire worship it. He had not learned the lesson that God cannot be captured in any created thing. The three young Hebrews refused to worship it as a god. They were faithful to the Lord, and the Lord rescued them from the king's wrath.

Daniel 3:2

The various classes of people listed here were all governmental officials.

Daniel 3:5

Pipes could be rendered "drums," or possibly this was a word of musical direction that indicated being "in harmony" with the other instruments.

Daniel 3:7

all the people: Outside of Israel, idol worship was normal, so all the non-Jewish people obeyed the king's command.

Daniel 3:11

In some situations, the Lord's people must refuse to obey the established authorities in order to remain faithful to the Lord (cp. [Acts 4:19](#); [5:29](#); [Rom 13:1-7](#)).

Daniel 3:12

These Jews had defied his Majesty the king, specifically by refusing to worship his statue. Defying the king was an act of high treason (cp. [2:10-13](#)).

Daniel 3:13

Nebuchadnezzar was capable of deadly rage against even his most honored officials (cp. [2:12, 48-49](#)).

Daniel 3:14

Is it true ... ? The Aramaic word is used only here in the Old Testament. The king may have been asking, "Are your actions deliberate?"

Daniel 3:15

I will give you one more chance: The three men's earlier relationship to the king may have helped them get a second chance.

Daniel 3:16–18

The three men declared their faithfulness to God above all. They were entrusting themselves to the God who had rescued the entire nation of Israel from the power of Pharaoh ([Exod 18:10](#)). God later revealed that those who remain faithful unto death will be delivered even after they have died ([Dan 12:1–3](#)).

Daniel 3:23

In the Greek version and the Latin Vulgate, *The Prayer of Azariah* and *The Song of the Three Jews* are inserted after [3:23](#) (see Daniel Book Introduction, “Author and Date”).

Daniel 3:25

walking around: The same word is used in [Gen 3:8–9](#). • like a god (literally *like a son of the gods*): The king understood the being as the Lord’s angel ([Dan 3:28](#)).

Daniel 3:26

The title Most High is often used to refer to God (e.g., [4:2](#), [24–25](#); [7:25](#); [Gen 14:18](#); [Num 24:16](#); [Deut 32:8–9](#); [Ps 73:11](#); [Isa 14:14](#)). In Canaanite religion, it often referred to Baal.

Daniel 3:28

The king was surprised that God could rescue his people, but the three Hebrew men knew that their God could deliver them ([3:17](#)).

Daniel 3:30

promoted: A related word is used in [Gen 39:2](#). The men were rewarded for their righteousness and their faithfulness to the Lord.

Daniel 4:1–37

In his pride, King Nebuchadnezzar convinced himself that he had built Babylon ([4:30](#); cp. [Gen 11:1–9](#)). He disregarded the warning of the Most

High God ([Dan 4:24–27](#)). He had still not learned the lesson God was teaching him through these experiences, that the God of Daniel stands outside the world of time and space, and no human is equal to him. So God’s decree of judgment fell upon Nebuchadnezzar ([4:17](#), [25–26](#); see [Prov 16:18](#)).

Daniel 4:4

God did not allow the king to remain in the comfort and prosperity of his palace; injustice and oppression were in the city ([4:27](#)), and the king was full of pride ([4:30](#)).

Daniel 4:5

Nebuchadnezzar’s dream disrupted the false peace and serenity of the king’s misguided life.

Daniel 4:7

The professionals could not interpret the dream even though it was told to them this time (cp. [2:1–11](#)). Their dream manuals failed them (see study note on 2:4). • astrologers: See also [2:5](#), [10](#); [3:8](#); [5:7](#), [11](#), [30](#).

Daniel 4:8–9

At last: Nebuchadnezzar appealed first to his Babylonian advisers; in spite of his high position, Daniel, an exiled Jew, was a last resort. • spirit of the holy gods is in him: See [2:47](#); cp. [5:11](#). Despite his previous experience of the Most High God, Nebuchadnezzar still believed in many gods. In Egypt, Pharaoh had asserted the same thing of Joseph ([Gen 41:37–38](#)). It was the Most High God who assisted Daniel ([Dan 4:24](#)). Nevertheless, for the great king to say that Daniel had the spirit of the holy gods in him showed great respect and helps to explain Daniel’s immunity from harassment (see ch [3](#)).

Daniel 4:11

The tree . . . reaching high into the heavens possibly alludes to the Tower of Babel ([Gen 11:1–9](#)).

Daniel 4:13

a holy one: The term *holy* is not widely used in the Semitic languages outside of the Bible. It simply refers to that which is out of the ordinary or nonhuman. Nebuchadnezzar was most probably using it that way here.

Daniel 4:14-17

The messenger had full authority as the representative of the Most High to announce God's decrees and demand that they be fulfilled.

Daniel 4:16

Seven periods of time may refer to a seven-year period (cp. [7:25](#); [9:24-25](#)). • mind of a wild animal: See [4:31-33](#).

Daniel 4:17

the Most High rules: God distributes kingship and kingdoms to whomever he will, even to the lowliest (e.g., Joseph, [Gen 41:41-57](#); David, [1 Sam 16-2 Sam 5](#)).

Daniel 4:22

The tree is a haven of sustenance, rest, and safety for the world (cp. [Gen 2:15-17](#); [Rev 22:14](#)). • your greatness reaches up to heaven: Cp. [Gen 11:1-9](#).

Daniel 4:23

Cut down the tree: The tree must be cut down because of Nebuchadnezzar's pride ([4:27-30](#)).

Daniel 4:25-26

until you learn that the Most High rules: God's goal was proper recognition of God's rule.

Daniel 4:27

Stop sinning and do what is right: Righteousness and justice exalt a nation and extend the reign of a king; the lack of it dooms a people. Daniel humbly pled with the king to change his ways. • be merciful to the poor: This was a requirement of God's law ([Exod 23:6-11](#); [Deut 15:10-11](#); [Prov 29:14](#); [31:9](#)) as well as Babylon's. A former great king of Babylon, Hammurabi (about 1792-1750 BC), claimed to have been charged by his god Marduk to shepherd and protect the orphaned, the widowed, and the oppressed. • Perhaps then: Daniel recognized that God was free to act or not act (cp. [Dan 3:16-18](#)); because he is a merciful God, he might take pity on the condemned king (cp. [Exod 32:30](#); [1 Sam 14:6](#); [2 Sam 12:22](#); [Joel 2:14](#); [Amos 5:15](#); [Zeph 2:3](#); [2 Tim 2:25](#)).

Daniel 4:28-33

Because Daniel's warning went unheeded, the dream became reality.

Daniel 4:30

The city of Babylon had magnificent walls covered with royal blue ceramic tile and gold-colored lions and dragons. The Hanging Gardens of Babylon were also part of the city's splendor, as was the dazzling Ishtar Gate. The king recognized all this as a reflection of his own glory and power, not as a gift of the Most High God.

Daniel 4:32

The king who took Israel into exile for seventy years experienced his own exile for seven periods of time until he was purified of his pride.

Daniel 4:33

This disease, called boanthropy, causes a person to behave like an ox. Several ancient sources lend support to this account, and the king's annals are notably empty from 582 to 575 BC.

Daniel 4:34-37

Nebuchadnezzar now acknowledged and submitted to the higher authority of the Most High, the King of heaven.

Daniel 4:35

He does as he pleases: God has absolute power in heaven and on earth.

Daniel 4:37

The Most High God is the King of heaven as well as of earth. Human pride has no place before him, even that of the greatest of human kings.

Daniel 5:1

Many years later: This chapter opens in October 539 BC (see study note on 5:30). • The name Belshazzar means “Bel Protects [the King]” (Bel was a Babylonian god). Nabonidus (556–539 BC) placed his son Belshazzar on the Babylonian throne around 553 BC as ruler in his stead. Then Nabonidus moved to Tema in northwest Arabia, where he stayed for ten years. He returned to Babylon only in the unsuccessful attempt to oppose the Persians (cp. [5:30-31](#)).

Daniel 5:1-30

Earthly kingdoms all pass away. As Nebuchadnezzar’s dream implied, Babylon would pass away and a new sovereign kingdom would take its place ([2:39](#)). After Nebuchadnezzar’s death in 562 BC, violence and debauchery increased in the palaces of Babylon until, during Belshazzar’s feast in 539 BC, even God’s holy vessels were polluted and defiled. God’s judgment came with lightning swiftness that night ([5:30](#)), and the next kingdom took over (see [2:32, 39; 5:31](#)).

Daniel 5:2-4

The gold and silver cups from the Temple in Jerusalem had been taken into captivity along with the people ([1:2](#)), but previous Babylonian kings had not defiled them. They were eventually

returned to Jerusalem ([Ezra 1:7-11](#)). • predecessor (literally *father*): Belshazzar was the oldest son of Nabonidus; his relationship with Nebuchadnezzar is uncertain. • While they drank from them they praised their idols: If Belshazzar had ever known of the honor Nebuchadnezzar had shown toward the Most High God decades earlier ([Dan 4:34-37](#)), he had long forgotten it. Two ancient Greek historians, Herodotus and Xenophon, record the all-night festivities, dancing, and excessive drinking that took place as the city was taken by Persia.

Daniel 5:5-6

The supernatural hand shocked and terrified the carousers. Yet Belshazzar remained unrepentant ([5:29](#); cp. [Jer 38:19-24; Acts 24:25](#)).

Daniel 5:7

Purple robes and a gold chain are associated with royalty and power. • third highest: After Nabonidus and Belshazzar himself (see study note on 5:1).

Daniel 5:8

As before, the Babylonian wise men were unable to interpret the omen (cp. [2:4-11; 4:7; 5:15](#)).

Daniel 5:10

the queen mother (literally *the queen*): She was probably Belshazzar’s mother, not his wife. • Long live the king! was the standard greeting (also in [2:4](#)); ironically, Belshazzar would die that night ([5:30](#)). • Don’t be so pale and frightened: Cp. [1 Sam 28:20-25](#).

Daniel 5:11-12

The queen mother reasoned that someone who had the spirit of the holy gods and could interpret dreams (see [1:17](#)) should also be able to interpret the writing.

Daniel 5:15

None of the Babylonian wise men could break the heavenly code (cp. [2:27](#); [4:7](#)). Only true wise men or prophets can interpret God's messages. Daniel knew that it was the Spirit of God who enabled him to do so (cp. [2:28](#); [5:24](#)).

Daniel 5:17

Daniel interpreted the writing but required no pay from the wicked king (cp. [Gen 14:21-24](#); [2 Kgs 5:15-16](#)).

Daniel 5:18-21

Daniel presented Nebuchadnezzar as an object lesson that should have guided his successors. Instead, Belshazzar had made the same mistake of exalting himself and dishonoring the Most High God.

Daniel 5:20

A rebel against God characteristically has a heart and mind that are puffed up (or *hardened*) with arrogance (see [Exod 7:13](#); [Josh 11:20](#); [Isa 14:3-5](#)). Nebuchadnezzar was brought down when he became puffed up with arrogance, and Belshazzar would be as well.

Daniel 5:21

the Most High God rules . . . and appoints anyone he desires: God had taught Nebuchadnezzar this lesson, and it was the heart of God's message to Belshazzar. God would appoint a new ruler that very night ([5:30-31](#)).

Daniel 5:25-28

Mene, Mene, Tekel, and Parsin: These Aramaic units of measure are used on a balance to weigh quantities of goods being bought and sold. Belshazzar knew the words, but Daniel explained what they meant in this context. The God of Israel measures kings and kingdoms in the balances of justice and righteousness (cp. [4:27](#)).

Daniel 5:26

Mene means 'numbered': In this context, it means "reckoned, scrutinized."

Daniel 5:27

Tekel means 'weighed'—you . . . have not measured up: Babylon's king would be destroyed because he did not measure up to God's demand for righteousness and mercy (see [4:27](#); [5:22-24](#)).

Daniel 5:28

Parsin means 'divided' (or *halved*): The Babylonian Empire would be divided and given to two peoples, the Medes and the Persians.

Daniel 5:29

Instead of responding to the message, Belshazzar honored Daniel. • proclaimed the third highest ruler: Daniel did not desire the honor, and in a few hours it would be meaningless. God would reward Daniel in due time ([12:13](#)).

Daniel 5:30

The conquest of Babylon by the Medes and Persians ushered in a new era of Persian dominance.

Daniel 5:31

Darius the Mede is distinct from later Persian kings named Darius (see "The Medes and Persians" Profile). Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539 BC, and there is no mention of a Darius the Mede in other sources. Two solutions are possible:

1. Cyrus the Great might have chosen Darius the Mede to rule as "King of Babylon" in his place for a little over a year (compare [Dan 6:28](#); [9:1](#); [11:1](#)).

2. Darius and Cyrus might have been the same man bearing two throne names—one name from the Medes, the other from the Persians (see also study note on 6:28).

The portrayal of Darius in ch 6 suggests that he was in fact Cyrus, the ruler of all Media, Persia, and Babylonia.

Daniel 6:1–28

God rescued and delivered his faithful servant Daniel ([5:23](#); [6:20](#)), whereas Belshazzar's dead gods could not save him.

Daniel 6:2

The three administrators placed over the whole territory reported directly to the king. • and protect the king's interests: Rebels could bring down the empire, so these administrators had to be absolutely trustworthy.

Daniel 6:3

the king made plans to place him over the entire empire: Cp. [2:48–49](#); [3:30](#); [Gen 41:40–43](#).

Daniel 6:3–5

Daniel's integrity was unassailable and his abilities unmatched, so the envious administrators found fault with Daniel's strongest point, his faithful worship of God. Daniel was about 80~85 years old at this time. He had led an exemplary life in Babylon.

Daniel 6:5

rules of his religion: Literally *law* [or *requirements*] of his God (cp. [6:8](#), [12](#), [15](#); [Ezra 7:12](#), [14](#), [25](#)).

Daniel 6:7

the king should make a law: The request was couched as an appeal to truth and justice, but it was

really an appeal to the king's pride, with ulterior motives ([6:4–5](#)). • We already know that Daniel would not break God's law to obey a human order (cp. [1:5–8](#); [3:4–12](#)).

Daniel 6:8

cannot be changed . . . cannot be revoked: Cp. [Esth 1:19](#). Human laws all pass away, but God's law lasts forever ([Pss 93:5](#); [119:152](#)). This devotion to established laws was one of the special features of the Persian Empire. Eventually, the profusion of laws so swamped them in bureaucracy that they could not function efficiently.

Daniel 6:10–11

as usual: Daniel's regular prayer time established him in the daily worship of God. • Jerusalem was God's chosen city ([1 Kgs 11:36](#)). Though the Temple was gone, it was unthinkable to forget Jerusalem ([Ps 137:5–6](#)). Someday, the Temple would be rebuilt ([Isa 2:2–4](#); [44:28](#)).

Daniel 6:14

The king had not thought through all the consequences of signing the law. • deeply troubled: Or *very angry* for being tricked. He did not want to execute his best servant.

Daniel 6:16

Caught in the officials' trap, the king had to carry out the law, but he respected Daniel's integrity in worshipping his God (cp. [3:15](#); [6:20](#)).

Daniel 6:17

his own royal seal and the seals of his nobles: The multiple sealing of the lions' den made a covert rescue impossible. Neither the king nor the officials could open the den without breaking the other seals and thus informing the other parties.

Daniel 6:18

The king spent the night fasting because he mourned over what he had done and hoped that Daniel's God would rescue him. The king couldn't sleep at all because he knew that Daniel was an innocent and noble man.

Daniel 6:19

Very early: Literally *at dawn*, the earliest possible hour.

Daniel 6:20

Was your God . . . able? There was no question about whether Daniel had served God faithfully, so if God didn't rescue him it would have told the king that God was not able to do so. • living God: The king probably knew what Daniel's God had done during the reigns of Nebuchadnezzar and Belshazzar. The expression *living God* is particularly used in the Bible to contrast the Lord with lifeless idols (see, e.g., [Deut 5:26](#); [Josh 3:10](#); [Isa 37:17-18](#)).

Daniel 6:21-22

My God sent his angel: The law of the Medes and Persians proved impotent. God has the power to defend his faithful servant and his own reputation.

Daniel 6:25-27

King Darius sent this message: As Nebuchadnezzar had done previously (cp. [3:28-29](#); [4:34-37](#)), the current ruler of the civilized world testified to all his subjects that the God of Daniel is the living God with real power and a kingdom that will never be destroyed.

Daniel 6:27

He rescues and saves. . . . He has rescued Daniel: This proclamation moves from the general to the specific. Daniel was a specific example of God's rescuing power. God continues to act on behalf of his people, just as he has always done.

Daniel 6:28

the reign of Darius and the reign of Cyrus the Persian: Or *the reign of Darius, that is, the reign of Cyrus the Persian*. Such usage of "and" is common in Aramaic; many believe that Cyrus and Darius were one man (see study note on 5:31).

Daniel 7:1

Earlier: This vision occurred before the events in ch [6](#). • Daniel wrote down this vision.

Daniel 7:1-28

This chapter contains a terrifying vision ([7:2-14](#)) and its interpretation ([7:17-27](#)). The sequence of kingdoms recalls Nebuchadnezzar's dream some forty-five years earlier ([2:1-45](#)).

Daniel 7:1-12.13

The second half of the book features visions given to Daniel. These visions showed Daniel and his people, both those in exile and those who had returned to Judea, that the future is securely in God's hands. All empires will ultimately fall before the Kingdom of Heaven. Daniel's people will be rescued from all their troubles ([12:1-3](#)), and God will resurrect and judge all humankind (see [12:13](#)). Daniel interpreted these visions with help from divine messengers ([7:10](#); [8:15](#); [9:22](#); [10:14](#); [12:7](#)).

Daniel 7:2

The sea is an image of evil or chaos in the Old Testament (see [Ps 89:10](#); [Isa 5:30](#); [57:20](#)), as it was throughout the ancient Near East.

Daniel 7:3-7

The kingdoms of the world are represented as four huge beasts ([7:17](#); cp. [Rev 13:1-2](#)).

Daniel 7:4

The lion and eagle are dignified rulers in their realms. Lions featured prominently in ancient art and architecture. Nebuchadnezzar and Babylon are represented as a lion and an eagle attacking Edom ([Jer 49:19, 22](#)). • This beast became like a human being and was given a human mind: Nebuchadnezzar had taken on the mind of a beast ([Dan 4:16, 32-33](#)), but then he was restored and learned to acknowledge the Most High God ([4:34-37](#)).

Daniel 7:5

The second beast probably represents Persia ([2:34-40; 6:9, 12, 15; 8:20](#)). • The bear was known for its vicious attacks ([Prov 28:15](#)). Three ribs may refer to Babylon, Media, and Lydia, all of which Cyrus conquered. • many people: God called Cyrus and Persia to conquer many nations ([Isa 41:2-3; 44:28; 45:1, 13; 46:11](#)).

Daniel 7:6

The leopard was known for its speed and agility ([Hab 1:8](#)). Four bird's wings and four heads indicate the scope and speed of this fierce nation's military campaigns. Greece conformed to this symbolism well, especially under Alexander the Great, whose kingdom was divided into four parts following his death in 323 BC.

Daniel 7:7

The fourth beast was different in kind, not just degree. It was made of nonliving metal. It was hardly animal; it was impersonal, utterly violent, and merciless, and even its iron teeth were a perfect killing machine. Most commentators, both ancient and modern, find this fourth beast best embodied in the Roman Empire and its kings. • ten horns: In this kind of apocalyptic literature, horns can stand for kings, power, and strength.

Daniel 7:8

Many believe that the fourth kingdom was only partially and preliminarily represented in Rome. Another more brutal kingdom beyond Rome, but

like it, would come through the dominion of a final little horn, a human being with great power and arrogance (cp. [8:9-12, 23-25; 9:25-27; 11:36-45; 12:1-7](#)).

Daniel 7:9-10

The kingdoms of the world are represented by fierce animals; the Kingdom of God is represented by a divine-human figure (also in [7:13-14](#)) and by holy people. • the Ancient One: This name is a circumlocution for God, whose existence preceded all the nations and peoples of the earth. • White . . . hair and clothing represent wisdom and purity. The river of fire speaks of God's purifying presence.

Daniel 7:10

Taken together, the millions and many millions indicate numbers beyond calculation. • the books: God keeps records and uses them as the basis for his judgment (cp. [10:21; 12:1; Exod 32:32; Pss 69:28; 139:16; Mal 3:16; Phil 4:3; Rev 20:12, 15; 21:27](#)).

Daniel 7:11

God's judgment brought about the destruction of the fourth beast . . . by fire.

Daniel 7:12

a while longer: God, the Judge of the nations, can extend the lives of nations and individuals (cp. [4:27](#)). Defeated nations who have lost their political and military hegemony can continue to live on culturally and ethnically, and can retain their national identities. This happened with the Assyrians, the Babylonians, the Persians, and the Greeks.

Daniel 7:13

like a son of man: He was like a human being (cp. [3:25](#)). • His coming with the clouds of heaven suggests that he was a divine being (cp. [Pss 68:4; 97:2; Matt 24:30; 26:64; Mark 13:26; 14:62; Luke 21:27; 1 Thes 4:17; Rev 1:7](#)).

Daniel 7:13-14

This being like a son of man, unlike the arrogant little horn, did not boast and was not violent. He did not violently overthrow other kings, and he received God's favor and blessing. He was led into God's presence and was presented to him. God gave him kingship and a kingdom. This figure is the Messiah, God's chosen and anointed King.

Daniel 7:14

Unlike the rulers and kingdoms of the earth, which pass away, his rule is eternal and will never be destroyed. His kingdom is given to the holy people of the Most High ([7:27](#)), and it "fills" the earth ([2:35, 44-45](#)).

Daniel 7:15-16

Daniel dared to approach the beings standing beside the throne of God, and he was helped, not harmed.

Daniel 7:17

beasts represent . . . kingdoms: God gave Daniel a vision of the course of history, a feat no human could accomplish. These kingdoms from the earth (cp. [7:2](#)) are not heavenly kingdoms but human kingdoms of this world.

Daniel 7:18

The holy people (also in [7:21-22](#), [25](#), [27](#)) are people who belong exclusively to God and share his character. In Daniel's era it referred to the people of Israel. • Only the Most High God can declare what the end of history will be. Other ancient writers spoke of the ages or eras of earthly history, but none knew how it would all end.

Daniel 7:19-28

Daniel requested and received more information about the fourth beast, the ten horns, and the little horn.

Daniel 7:21

The object of the little horn's hatred and arrogance was God's holy people. In this, the little horn was like Pharaoh and Haman (see [Exod 1:22](#); [Esth 3:8-9](#); cp. [Dan 11:36-40](#)).

Daniel 7:22

The Ancient One turned the tide of the battle when he judged in favor of his holy people. In God's time, his people would take over the kingdom with their King ([7:13-14](#)).

Daniel 7:24-25

Its ten horns are ten kings: This number might refer to ten specific individuals, or it might be a symbolic number meaning that this kingdom lasted through the reigns of many kings (cp. [Rev 13:1](#)). • Then another king, who corresponds to the "little horn" ([Dan 7:21](#)), will defy the Most High and oppress the holy people by blaspheming the Lord, trying to interfere with worship of the Lord, trying to make the holy people follow his religion, and subjecting them to constant threats. • a time, times, and half a time: The text is not explicit as to the length of time. Nonetheless, the period of oppression for the holy people would be limited and would end suddenly and unexpectedly.

Daniel 7:26

God's court has the authority to pass judgment and the power to remove and destroy this arrogant king.

Daniel 7:27

When this arrogant king has been destroyed, God's kingdom will be established forever over all the kingdoms under heaven (cp. [Ps 2](#); [Isa 9:6-7](#)). The holy people of the Most High are officers of God's kingdom (cp. [Luke 22:29-30](#); [1 Cor 6:2-3](#); [Rev 3:21](#); [20:4](#)).

Daniel 8:1

The author probably changes back to Hebrew because he now focuses again (as with [1:1-2:4a](#)) on the holy people, Israel, for the remainder of the book. • The third year of King Belshazzar's reign was around 554~551 BC. It was about two years after the vision of ch [7](#) and over a decade before the fall of Babylon in 539 BC ([5:31](#)).

Daniel 8:1-27

This vision expands the vision of ch [7](#), developing additional symbolism regarding the second and third beasts ([7:5-6](#)). Its report about a small horn that arises from the goat has similarities with the "little horn" of [7:8](#), [20-25](#); the "ruler" of [9:26-27](#); and the "despicable man" of [11:21-45](#).

Daniel 8:2

Susa, located in the lowlands southwest of the Zagros Mountains, was one of Persia's capital cities (cp. [Ezra 4:9](#); [Neh 1:1](#); [Esth 1:2](#)). It was a fortified capital whose architecture was decorated with glazed griffins, winged bulls, and lions. • The Ulai River was probably a man-made canal.

Daniel 8:3-4

Two long horns implies that there were two major nations in this kingdom represented by a ram (see [8:20-21](#)). • God allowed the nation to do as it pleased; God was still in control (cp. [Isa 45:1-4](#)).

Daniel 8:5-12

The symbolism is explained in [8:21-25](#).

Daniel 8:10

The heavenly army could refer to (1) actual divine beings, since the "small horn" attempted to destroy Israel's divinely given religion and Israel was protected by God's watchful eye and his armies; and/or (2) the human defenders of Israel that were fighting for God's holy people and the Temple. Both the physical and the spiritual realms were affected by these events.

Daniel 8:11-12

God is the Commander of heaven's army (cp. [Josh 5:13-15](#); [1 Sam 4:4](#); [1 Kgs 22:19](#)) to whom the daily sacrifices were offered in his Temple, where God's name resided and Israel worshiped its King ([Isa 18:7](#); [Ezek 43:6-7](#)). • destroying (literally *casting down*): The religious function of the Temple was disabled. • God restrained the heavenly army for reasons known only to him. • The truth of God's law, embodied in true worship, was also overthrown (literally *cast down*).

Daniel 8:13–14

- How long: God’s people were called to endure this difficult time until it ended.
- about the 2,300 evenings and mornings: This could either mean a period of 1,150 days (1,150 evenings and 1,150 mornings, about three and a half years) or 2,300 days (about seven years). These times match important events in history:
 - In 171 BC, Antiochus IV removed Onias III from his position as high priest.
 - In December 167 BC, he treated the temple with disrespect and offered unclean sacrifices.
 - In December 164 BC, the temple and the altar were cleansed and used again for proper worship. This was seven years after Onias lost his position, and just over three years after the temple was made unclean (see *1 Maccabees* 1:54; 4:52–53; *2 Maccabees* 10:5).
- The temple would then be made right for its proper religious use. It would not be rebuilt physically (see [8:11–12](#); study note on 8:26).

Daniel 8:15–16

The name Gabriel means “man of God”; he appeared like a man to Daniel (see also [9:21](#); [Luke 1:19, 26](#)).

Daniel 8:17

Son of man means “human being,” as opposed to a divine being, “a son of the gods” (cp. [7:13](#); see, e.g., [Ezek 2:1, 3, 6, 8](#)).

Daniel 8:19

the very end of time: There is an appointed time for the end of history.

Daniel 8:19–26

These verses provide the interpretation of the vision of [8:3–14](#).

Daniel 8:20

The smaller horn represents Media, which began as an independent kingdom in 670 BC. The larger horn represents Persia, which dominated Media during Cyrus’s reign (see [7:5](#)).

Daniel 8:21

The large horn represents Alexander the Great, the mighty first king who forged the Greek Empire. Two centuries after Daniel, Alexander would swiftly conquer the world ([8:5](#)); he overcame Persia in 331 BC. Alexander died in 323 BC at the age of thirty-three, but not before he arrogantly allowed himself to be called a god. • Josephus records that some Jewish priests showed the book of Daniel to Alexander, but Alexander treated Homer’s *Iliad* as his Bible and relied on it for guidance.

Daniel 8:22

After Alexander’s death in 323 BC, his kingdom was divided into four major kingdoms, ruled by his generals (see “The Greeks” Profile).

Daniel 8:23–25

The small horn ([8:9](#)) was a fierce king. The description matches Antiochus IV (175–163 BC), one of the Seleucids (cp. [11:21–45](#)). He bore the name “Epiphanes” (“The Manifest Presence [of God]”), but many, including Jews, mockingly called him “Epimanes” (“Mad Man”). By desecrating the Temple and Jewish worship ([8:11–12](#)), Antiochus tried to destroy Judaism and unify his kingdom under the cult of Hellenistic culture. Some Jews

were swept up in the program of Hellenism and adopted Greek ways.

Daniel 8:24

not by his own power: God remained in sovereign control of the seemingly fortuitous events of history that brought Antiochus IV to power. • a shocking amount of destruction: See *1 Maccabees* 1:10–63, which describes many of the evils that Antiochus IV instigated.

Daniel 8:25

The Prince of princes is the King of Israel, the ruler of heaven and earth ([7:9–10](#), [13–14](#)). Antiochus, at the time of his death, exalted himself as God and intended to destroy Jerusalem. • he will be broken: Just as Antiochus IV's rise was not by his own power ([8:24](#)), so he was destroyed by God's hand rather than by human power. His end was to be eaten by worms (*1 Maccabees* 6:7–16 and *2 Maccabees* 9:4–28; cp. Herod Agrippa, [Acts 12:20–23](#)).

Daniel 8:26

seal up the vision: It would have been unwise for Daniel to share this vision at that time during Belshazzar's reign. Sharing it might have looked like Daniel was planning to rebel or betray the king.

Daniel 9:1

Darius the Mede: See study note on 5:31. • Ahasuerus is the Hebrew rendering of a Persian word taken into Greek as "Xerxes." The father of Darius the Mede must have been a different Xerxes from the later Xerxes I, who reigned from 486 to 465 BC (see [Esth 1:1](#)); the time of this vision was 539 BC. It has been argued that the name Xerxes/Ahasuerus is an ancient throne name for Persian kings.

Daniel 9:1–19

Daniel prayed for his people, realizing that Jerusalem's seventy years of desolation were due to end. His prayer is comparable to prayers of

Solomon ([1 Kgs 8:14–61](#)), Ezra ([Ezra 9](#)), and Nehemiah ([Neh 9](#)). God answered Daniel's prayer very quickly (see study note on Dan 9:19; see also [9:20–27](#)).

Daniel 9:2

reading . . . Jeremiah: Daniel apparently had a copy of Jeremiah's prophecies. • Jerusalem must lie desolate for seventy years: Jerusalem was destroyed in 586 BC (see [2 Kgs 25:8](#)), and the first return occurred in 538 BC—about 48 years later. The rebuilding of the city began almost at once (see [Ezra 3:1–13](#); [Isa 44:28](#)), and the rebuilt Temple was completed in 515 BC—about seventy-one years after it was destroyed ([Ezra 6:15](#)). Daniel might have thought of Jerusalem's "destruction" as having begun with his own exile in 605 BC (see [Jer 25:11–12](#)), with sixty-seven years between 605 and 538 BC.

Daniel 9:3

Daniel realized that the seventy years were nearly at an end, so he turned to the Lord God seeking restoration for his people and the city of Jerusalem. • People in mourning often wore burlap and ashes (cp. [Neh 9:1](#); [Esth 4:1](#); [Lam 2:10](#); [Luke 10:13](#)). • Focused prayer was often accompanied by fasting to put spiritual concerns ahead of physical needs.

Daniel 9:4

the Lord (Hebrew *Yahweh*): The covenant name of God ([Exod 6:2–3](#); [20:2](#)) is found in Daniel only in this chapter. • God is faithful to his covenant with his people who love . . . and obey him (cp. [Exod 34:6–7](#); [Deut 7:9](#); [Rom 8:28](#)). God's unfailing love (Hebrew *khesed*, elsewhere translated "grace," "mercy," "kindness") is his fundamental nature that is the cause of faith, hope, and worship throughout the Bible (see [Num 14:18](#); [Neh 9:17](#); [Pss 108:4](#); [136:1–26](#); [Jon 2:4](#); [1 Jn 4:7–8](#)).

Daniel 9:4–11

God's faithfulness contrasted sharply with his people's unfaithfulness and rebellion. When Daniel confessed the sins of his people, he included himself among them ([9:5](#)), though he had lived a

laudatory life (see “Community Identity” Theme Note). Daniel prayed the equivalent of a high priestly prayer on behalf of his people, using many quotations from and allusions to the Torah, prophets, and psalms.

Daniel 9:5

Daniel used four different words meaning sin: The people had sinned (literally *missed the mark*), done wrong (i.e., committed a bent or twisted act), rebelled against the covenant, and scorned (literally *turned away from*) the Lord’s instructions.

Daniel 9:6

God’s servants the prophets were his specially called and inspired spokesmen ([9:10](#); [Deut 18:15-22](#); [2 Kgs 17:23](#); [21:10-15](#); [Jer 7:25](#); [25:4](#)).

Daniel 9:7-14

Lord, you are in the right: God orchestrated the Exile as a judgment on unfaithful Israel ([9:11-14](#)). God had given ample warning that it would happen (see [Deut 28:36-37](#), [49-68](#)).

Daniel 9:12

God’s act of driving Israel into exile for breaking his covenant was unique in all of history. Israel’s exodus from Egypt, their exile, and their return from Babylon are still unequaled (see also [Jer 29:10](#)).

Daniel 9:13

Every curse written against us in the Law of Moses is summarized in [Lev 26](#) and [Deut 27-28](#). When the people entered into the covenant they swore to be obedient, calling down curses on themselves if they failed (see [Exod 24:7-8](#); [Josh 8:34-35](#)).

Daniel 9:15

God could bring lasting honor to his name by rescuing his people from exile in Babylonia, just as

he did when he rescued them from Egypt (cp. [Ezek 36:19-24](#)).

Daniel 9:15-19

Daniel cried out for God to rescue his people and end the Exile, relying on God’s mercy and God’s desire to honor his own name. Daniel’s prayer is among the great intercessory prayers of God’s Old Testament people (see also [Exod 32:11-14](#); [Ezra 9:1-15](#); [Neh 9:1-37](#)).

Daniel 9:16

mock Jerusalem and your people: God’s name was dishonored when his chosen city and his chosen people were ridiculed because of their helplessness before their enemies, making it appear that their God was helpless ([9:19](#); cp. [Ezek 36:19-20](#)).

Daniel 9:17

For your own sake: That is, for God’s own honor ([9:19](#)).

Daniel 9:18

because of your mercy: God’s compassionate and merciful character gave Daniel hope (cp. [Exod 34:6](#); [Jon 4:1-3](#); [Mic 6:8](#)).

Daniel 9:19

listen and act! . . . do not delay: Daniel prayed this prayer in 539 BC (see study note on 9:1). Shortly thereafter (in 538 BC), King Cyrus gave his decree allowing the Jewish people to return to Judea ([Ezra 1:1-4](#)). The new Temple in Jerusalem was completed in 515 BC ([Ezra 6:15](#)). God returned the Israelites from exile in response to their prayers and repentance, just as the Exile had been his response to his people’s sins and rebellion. • your people and your city bear your name: God’s reputation was associated with Jerusalem ([Neh 1:9](#)) and his people, Israel ([Exod 5:22-6:1](#)).

Daniel 9:20–27

God's immediate answer to Daniel's prayer was to send his messenger Gabriel to explain Daniel's vision. Gabriel's explanation covered the near and distant future of Daniel's people.

Daniel 9:21

Gabriel . . . earlier vision: See [8:15–16](#). • evening sacrifice: Before the destruction of the Temple, Israel had offered two sacrificial lambs daily, one in the morning and one in the evening ([Exod 29:41](#)). Daniel apparently observed these times daily with prayer ([Dan 6:10, 13](#); cp. [Ps 55:17](#)).

Daniel 9:22

In the book of Daniel, insight and understanding are key words that often refer to the meaning of God's revelation (cp. [1:4](#); [9:13, 25](#); [11:33, 35](#)). God did not promise Daniel the answers to all of his questions, but rather, a basic grasp of the issues. God is in charge of history.

Daniel 9:23

a command was given (literally *a word went forth*): This command might have been God's decree to end the Exile and return his people to Jerusalem and Judea, or it might have been the command to explain the future to Daniel ([9:24–27](#)). • you are very precious to God: Also in [10:11, 19](#). • It is unclear what your vision refers to: It could be the restoration of Jerusalem and God's people that Daniel read about in Jeremiah and envisioned in his prayer ([9:2–20](#)), or one of the earlier visions (e.g., ch [8](#); cp. [8:27](#)).

Daniel 9:24

Many understand the period of seventy sets of seven as seventy “weeks of years”—i.e., 490 years. However, they are not called “years” in the Hebrew text, and it has proven difficult to assign this period to an actual historical period of 490 years. Therefore, many interpreters believe that the numbers are not intended as calendar years but as symbolic periods of time to fulfill the visions. Just as Jerusalem suffered a lifetime of desolation ([9:2](#);

see study note on [Jer 25:11](#)), the city would experience many lifetimes of restoration. • The period of time was for your people (the Jews) and your holy city (Jerusalem). The six purposes listed here appear to refer to the restoration of the Jews and the city of Jerusalem. Other interpreters see these six purposes as representing God's universal work of redemption in the world. • God would finish the rebellion of the Israelites, and he would also finish the rebellions of human rulers who defy the Lord and attack the holy people ([Dan 7:8, 22, 25–26](#); [8:13–14](#); [11:29–45](#)). • To confirm the prophetic vision means to fulfill the content of the visionary answer to Daniel's prayer. • the Most Holy Place (Or *the Most Holy One*; literally *a most holy*): Some interpreters see this as referring to the restored Most Holy Place in the Temple in 164 BC. Others see it as referring to the anointing of Christ and his church as God's own temple ([Matt 12:6](#); [Eph 2:19–22](#)).

Daniel 9:24–27

Gabriel further explained the meaning of Daniel's vision ([9:22–23](#)). Because the vision of ch [8](#) culminated with Antiochus IV (see [8:23–25](#); cp. [11:21–39](#)), many interpreters understand this explanation as also pointing to Antiochus. Others understand it as culminating in the death of Christ, followed by the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 and the coming of the antichrist.

Daniel 9:25

The command . . . to rebuild Jerusalem and its Temple marks the beginning of the seventy sets of seven. The event that best fits this description is the decree of Cyrus the Great in 538 BC that allowed the Jews to return to Jerusalem and begin rebuilding (see [5:31](#); [9:1](#); [Ezra 1:2–4](#)). Less likely are the decrees of Artaxerxes I in 458 BC (see [Ezra 7:12–26](#)) and 445 BC (see [Neh 2:5–8](#)). • a ruler—the Anointed One: Many interpreters see Christ as fulfilling this prophecy, so they understand this passage as describing history from the time of Daniel to the time of Christ. However, an “anointed one” can refer to any of Israel's kings or priests, who were ordained by anointing with oil. If the passage was fulfilled in the time of Antiochus IV, then the anointed one was probably the high priest at the time, Onias III (cp. [Dan 11:22](#)). • and strong defenses: The vision refers to Jerusalem as being

physically rebuilt. The rebuilding of the Temple was completed in 515 BC ([Ezra 3:1–6:22](#)); in 445 BC, Nehemiah completed the wall of Jerusalem ([Neh 2–6](#)). • The perilous times can refer to the history of Jerusalem and its Temple from the time the decree was published until the end of the seventy sets of seven (see [Dan 11:2–45](#)).

Daniel 9:26

the Anointed One (literally *an anointed*): Those who see the fulfillment of this passage in the time of Antiochus IV point to the murder of the high priest Onias III in 171 BC as the fulfillment of this prophecy (see study note on 11:22). Those who see the fulfillment of this passage in the time of Christ will refer this prophecy to the crucifixion of the Messiah in AD 30 or 33. • The ruler who will arise could refer to Antiochus IV, who attempted to destroy the Jewish people and their worship in the Temple between 171 and 164 BC (see *1 Maccabees* 1:20–40). Many believe, however, that the destruction of the city and the Temple refers to the destruction of Jerusalem by the Romans in AD 66–70. • The end refers to the completion of the seventy sets of seven. The text implies that the very end is a later time, and that the war would continue into the future (cp. [Matt 24:4–8](#); [Mark 13:5–8](#)). • The image of a flood often represents an invading army (cp. [Dan 11:10](#), [22](#), [40](#); [Nah 1:8](#)) or devastating destruction.

Daniel 9:27

The ruler (literally *he*): Most interpreters understand this pronoun as referring to the ruler of [9:26](#). Some think that it refers back to the anointed one of [9:25–26](#) and is thus a prophecy about Christ, meaning that Christ caused a covenant to prevail and removed the need for sacrifices and offerings by his death. However, the word behind make a treaty has the sense of imposing a covenant, evidently by the use of force or intimidation. Antiochus IV imposed a covenant with the people of Judea following the beginning of his rule in 175 BC (cp. [11:23](#); see *1 Maccabees* 1:10–15). Other interpreters believe that this prophecy was fulfilled in the events of AD 66–70. For still others, it refers to a future ruler. • The phrase put an end refers to a destructive action, not an act of God's salvation such as the Messiah would accomplish by his death. In 167 BC, Antiochus IV ordered the people of Judea

to cease all practice of Jewish worship in the Temple and instead practice pagan worship, on pain of death (see *1 Maccabees* 1:41–63). Similarly, the Roman general Titus put an end to the sacrifices and offerings in the Temple when he destroyed it in AD 70. • a sacrilegious object that causes desecration (literally *an abomination of desolation*): Cp. [Dan 8:13](#); [11:31](#); [12:11](#). This expression (Hebrew *shiqqutsim meshomem*) is possibly a mocking play on the Semitic name for Zeus (*Ba'al Shamayim*, "Lord of the Heavens"). Idol-gods are often referred to as *shiqquts*, "abomination," "desolation," elsewhere in the Bible (see [Deut 29:17](#); [2 Chr 15:8](#); [Isa 66:3](#); [Jer 32:34](#); [Ezek 20:7](#)), and the similarity between the sounds of *shomem*, "devastation, destruction, desolation," and *shamayim* is clear. In December 167 BC, Antiochus IV erected an image of Zeus atop the altar of burnt offering in the Temple court and sacrificed unclean animals there. The same phrase (*abomination of desolation*) is used in *1 Maccabees* 1:54 to describe that altar and its sacrifices. Jesus and multiple New Testament authors anticipated a desolating sacrilege in the future ([Matt 24:15](#); [Mark 13:14](#); [Luke 21:20](#); [2 Thes 2:3–4](#)). After Titus destroyed the Temple in Jerusalem in AD 70, the Romans set up their idols in the Temple precinct and made sacrifices to their gods (see Josephus, *War* 6.6.1). The apostle John later observed that many antichrists had appeared ([1 Jn 2:18–23](#)) and that the spirit of the antichrist was at work in the world ([1 Jn 4:3](#)). • The time of destruction is under God's control, and the fate decreed for this defiler is certain to come (cp. [Dan 7:11](#); [8:25](#); [11:45](#)). So it is with every ruler who exalts himself against God and seeks to destroy God's people.

Daniel 10:1

The third year of the reign of King Cyrus was 536 BC, not long after Cyrus issued his decree for the peoples and nations to return to their ancestral homes ([2 Chr 36:22–23](#); [Ezra 1:1–2](#)). Daniel's prayer ([Dan 9:4–19](#)) had been answered—the Exile had ended. • Belteshazzar: See [1:7](#).

Daniel 10:1–12.13

This final vision reaches historically from 536 BC to a distant future when Daniel would be raised from the dead and receive his inheritance. All earthly kingdoms would be destroyed, the eternal

kingdom of the Son of Man would arise, God's people would finally be rescued, and death—the ultimate enemy—would be defeated.

Daniel 10:2-3

Daniel was apparently in mourning because of his previous visions ([10:14](#), [16](#)).

Daniel 10:5-6

The man dressed in linen clothing is an unidentified messenger of the Lord (cp. [10:16](#), [18](#); [12:6-7](#); see also [Ezek 9:3](#)).

Daniel 10:7-9

Daniel's response was typical for humans in the presence of heavenly beings (cp. [Josh 5:14](#); [Isa 6:5](#); [Acts 9:7-9](#); [Rev 1:17](#)).

Daniel 10:11

very precious to God: See also [9:23](#); [10:19](#).

Daniel 10:13

the spirit prince: The spiritual forces behind the various nations, such as the spirit prince of Persia or the spirit prince of Greece, blocked the way of God's messenger who responded to the prayers of God's people (see [10:20-11:1](#)). • one of the archangels: An archangel was a chief among God's heavenly messengers. • Daniel's world, and ours, is populated by more than meets the human eye. Daniel is shown the great events of history enacted against the background of a real spiritual world where spiritual beings support or hinder God's people, where the conflicts of the ages are also carried out. Behind all of this, the Ancient One sovereignly guides all things and sits in judgment upon the process and its conclusion. God's covenant with his people, and their relationship with him through prayer, are central to this process—the world is not ultimately governed by angels and spirit princes, but by the Ancient One, who hears the prayers of his people.

Daniel 10:16

touched my lips: Cp. [Exod 4:11-12](#); [Isa 6:5-7](#).

Daniel 10:19

God's word gives strength to his servants (cp. [Pss 29:11](#); [68:35](#)).

Daniel 10:20

The messenger described empires in terms of the spirit prince representing each of them. The Persian Empire had just begun and would later be replaced by the Greek Empire (cp. [8:3-7](#), [19-21](#)).

Daniel 10:21

Book of Truth (literally *writing of truth*): The messenger was not speaking of himself, but from what was written in God's Book of Truth. Compare God's book in [7:9-10](#); [Exod 32:32-33](#). See also [Dan 12:1](#); [Ps 139:16](#). The Book of Truth contains what is revealed in [Dan 11:2-12:7](#). • against these spirit princes except Michael, your spirit prince: God divided up the nations, partitioning out the nations and their princes ([Deut 32:8](#)). God was over Israel, and Michael was Israel's spirit prince.

Daniel 11:1

Darius the Mede: See study note on 5:31; the first year was probably 539 BC.

Daniel 11:2

Three more Persian kings: These Persian kings who followed Cyrus II were most likely Cambyses (530–522 BC), Gaumata (522 BC, a usurper), and Darius I (521–486 BC). The fourth was probably Xerxes I (486–465 BC; see study note on [Esth 1:1](#)), whose riches were legendary, as were his army of 1,700,000 soldiers and his huge navy (see Herodotus, *Histories* 7.6), which he used to fight against the kingdom of Greece. He was unsuccessful, as the Persians failed to defeat the growing power of Greece. God's sovereign hand was at work behind the historical events of this chapter.

Daniel 11:2–12.7

The messenger provided a grand sweep of history, from the time of Persia, through the break-up of Greece, the rise and defeat of a wicked king or series of kings ([11:21–45](#)), and the final resurrection and triumph of God's people.

Daniel 11:3

The mighty king was Alexander the Great (see study note on 8:21, 336–323 BC), who conquered much of the known world in thirteen years, from Greece to India and from far into the north to Egypt in the south.

Daniel 11:4

Alexander died on June 10, 323 BC, in Babylon at the age of thirty-three. He was at the height of his power and willing to be worshiped as a god. • Alexander's descendants were not capable of governing, and his brother Philip was incompetent. • For his empire will be . . . given to others: Several of Alexander's generals divided his empire; by 301 BC, their conflicts had resulted in four parts (see [7:4–7](#); [8:8–12](#) and corresponding study notes). God orchestrates history, and its end belongs to him.

Daniel 11:5

The first king of the south was Ptolemy I Soter (323–285 BC). One of his own officials was Seleucus I Nicator (321–281 BC), who took over the rule of Syria. Both men were military commanders under Alexander the Great. Initially (320–198 BC), Palestine was under the control of the Ptolemies.

Daniel 11:5–45

Throughout this passage, the king of the south describes Alexander's general Ptolemy and his descendants, who ruled Egypt; the king of the north describes Alexander's general Seleucus and his descendants, who ruled Syria and Mesopotamia. In the period following Alexander's death, the kings of Egypt and Syria vied for control of the strategically located land of Palestine. The holy city and the holy

people lay between these two powers. These battles continued until their appointed end ([11:27, 35, 40, 45; 12:1, 7](#)). These events are described historically in *1, 2, and 3 Maccabees* and by Herodotus, Livy, Polybius, Porphyry, and Josephus.

Daniel 11:6

An alliance was formed between Antiochus II Theos, the king of the north (261–246 BC), and Ptolemy II Philadelphus, the king of the south (284–246 BC). Antiochus married Ptolemy's daughter Berenice Syra in 250 BC, then abandoned her in 246 BC. She and Antiochus were then murdered.

Daniel 11:7–8

one of her relatives: Berenice's brother, Ptolemy III Euergetes, became king of the south (246–221 BC), invaded Syria with his army, defeated the king of the north (Seleucus II Callinicus, 246–226 BC), occupied the fortress cities of Antioch and Seleucia, and built the Ptolemaic kingdom to its greatest extent. When he returned to Egypt, he took their idols with him, but left Seleucus II on the throne.

Daniel 11:9

Seleucus II, still the king of the north, tried to invade Egypt in 242 BC but was defeated by Ptolemy III.

Daniel 11:10–12

The sons of Seleucus II were Seleucus III Ceraunus (226–223 BC) and Antiochus III the Great (223–187 BC). • a mighty army that will advance like a flood: Antiochus III aggressively sought to regain lost territory, including Palestine. • as far as the enemy's fortress: Antiochus III advanced to Raphia on the border of Egypt in 217 BC. In the ensuing battle, the king of the south—Ptolemy IV Philopater (221–203 BC)—defeated Antiochus III and retained control of Palestine.

Daniel 11:12–13

Ptolemy IV's success was short lived. In 198 BC, the king of the north—Antiochus III—returned. • Antiochus III had been conquering lands to the north and east, from which he raised a fully equipped army far greater than before (cp. 3 *Maccabees* 1:1–5).

Daniel 11:14

A general uprising of Jews and rebel Egyptians who favored Antiochus III arose. The king of the south was Ptolemy V Epiphanes (203–181 BC). • they will not succeed: The Egyptian commander, Scopas, quelled the rebellion (200 BC).

Daniel 11:15

At Paneas in 198 BC, the king of the north (Antiochus III) defeated the Egyptian general Scopas, besieged and captured Sidon, a fortified city, and took control of Palestine.

Daniel 11:16

intent on destroying it: Antiochus III sought to hellenize the Jews and destroy their ancient customs, but he was flattered by Jews who received him well, and he granted them special privileges. They were allowed to live according to their own laws. His son Antiochus IV was not so accommodating ([11:21–39](#)).

Daniel 11:17

Antiochus III formed an alliance with Ptolemy V by giving his daughter, Cleopatra I, to Ptolemy V in marriage. Antiochus hoped to overthrow Egypt from within, but his plan failed when his daughter became loyal to Egypt, and Egypt formed an alliance with Rome.

Daniel 11:18

Antiochus III extended his holdings into the coastland—including Anatolia, Macedonia, and Greece—but he was defeated by the Romans in 191 and 190 BC. The prince was the famous Roman

general Scipio, who put a stop to Antiochus III's expansionist policies and caused him to retreat in shame from his western acquisitions.

Daniel 11:19

Antiochus III thereafter remained within his own fortresses, where he was assassinated in 187 BC.

Daniel 11:20

Antiochus III's successor was his son Seleucus IV Philopater (187–175 BC), who was known for his infamous act of sending Heliodorus, a tax collector, to exact large sums of money to maintain the royal splendor (but also to pay the ruinous tribute imposed on the Seleucids by Rome). Heliodorus attempted to plunder the Temple in Jerusalem but was divinely thwarted (see 2 *Maccabees* 3:1–40). Seleucus was murdered by Heliodorus after a very brief reign of seven years.

Daniel 11:21–39

The next to come to power was Antiochus IV Epiphanes (175–163 BC). He is also the “small horn” of [Dan 8:9–14, 23–26](#). He is described vividly in 1 *Maccabees* 1:7–6:16; 2 *Maccabees* 1:1–10:5; 4 *Maccabees* 4:15–18:5. Antiochus was despicable both because he had usurped the kingship and for his deeds as king. He was not in line for royal succession but usurped the throne from his brother's son.

Daniel 11:22

The covenant prince was Onias III, the high priest (cp. study notes on 9:25–26). He was removed by Antiochus IV in 175 BC and replaced by his brother Jason (2 *Maccabees* 4:7–10). In 171 BC, Onias was murdered by Menelaus, who then became high priest (171–162 BC). Menelaus supported Antiochus IV's program of hellenization (see study note on 9:27).

Daniel 11:23

deceitful promises: Antiochus IV introduced Greek religion into Judea, helped by lawless followers

who supported his policies (see *1 Maccabees* 1:11-15).

Daniel 11:24

richest areas of the land: Antiochus IV seized the riches of the Temple, took large tributes from Jerusalem, and stationed troops there (*1 Maccabees* 1:29-40).

Daniel 11:25-27

The king of the south was Ptolemy VI Philometor (181-146 BC). Antiochus IV attacked Egypt twice between 170 and 168 BC (*1 Maccabees* 1:17-19).

Daniel 11:28

Antiochus IV plundered Jerusalem and the Temple in 170 BC, killing thousands and enslaving others (*1 Maccabees* 1:20-42; *2 Maccabees* 5:1-23). His arrogance was unbounded (*1 Maccabees* 1:24-25; cp. [Dan 7:28](#); [8:9](#)).

Daniel 11:29-35

Antiochus IV invaded the south [Egypt] . . . once again (see Polybius, *Histories* 29.1). • The warships from western coastlands refers to the Romans. The Roman general Popilius Laenas drew a circle in the sand, forced Antiochus to stand inside it, and made him decide whether to return home or prepare for war with Rome before exiting the circle. Fearing the Roman fleet, Antiochus chose to withdraw and return home. He then vented his anger and humiliation against the Jews, the people of the holy covenant. He took Jerusalem in 167 BC and rewarded those who would come over to him. He polluted the altar (see [Dan 8:9-14](#), [23-26](#)), stopped the sacrifices, set up a statue of the Greek god Zeus in the Temple, and harassed and killed whoever refused to forsake the covenant (see *1 Maccabees* 1:62-64; cp. [Dan 9:27](#); [Matt 24:15](#)).

Daniel 11:31

the sacrilegious object that causes desecration: See study note on 9:27.

Daniel 11:32-35

The wise are those who know their God and his laws and follow them, even in a hostile and deceptive environment. Many were martyred for their faithfulness to God and his laws during this time (*1 Maccabees* 1:11; [7:19](#); *2 Maccabees* 6-7).

Daniel 11:34

A little help came when the family of Mattathias and those around them, who were called Maccabees, instigated a national revolt which Antiochus, occupied elsewhere, could not put down. In 164 BC, three years after the Temple had been desecrated, the Maccabees recaptured Jerusalem, removed the sacrilegious object (the statue of Zeus), cleansed the altar, and restored the daily sacrifices ([8:11-14](#), [26](#); *1 Maccabees* 1:59). This event is commemorated at *Hanukkah* (see [John 10:22](#)).

Daniel 11:36

Antiochus IV thought himself equal to God (*2 Maccabees* 9:1-10:12), but God would hem him in until the time of wrath was completed. • what has been determined will surely take place: Antiochus suddenly contracted a painful disease and died in 163 BC in the mountains of Persia (see [8:25](#); *1 Maccabees* 4:52-53; 6:16; *2 Maccabees* 9:4, 28; 10:5).

Daniel 11:36-40

Some interpreters see these verses as a transition from the earthly Antiochus IV to a character larger than history ([7:8](#)).

Daniel 11:37-38

no respect for the gods of his ancestors: Antiochus IV forsook the Syrian gods in order to worship Greek gods. • The god loved by women might be one of the Canaanite or Egyptian fertility deities. • No god of fortresses is known from history, but this description might be fulfilled by the lavish gifts that Antiochus gave to cities and to Greek temples,

perhaps to increase his reputation and power (see Livy, *History* 41.20).

Daniel 11:40

No known king of the south or king of the north did these things.

Daniel 11:40–45

Most commentators believe these verses describe the time of the end of history (cp. [Mark 13:14](#); [2 Thes 2:3–12](#); [Rev 19:19–21](#)). These verses echo the career of Antiochus IV, but we have no historical record of the events described here. Antiochus was a paradigm for future rulers who set themselves against the God of gods.

Daniel 11:41

the glorious land of Israel: Israel (cp. [8:9](#); [11:16](#)) is again the center of attack by an evil king. • Moab, Edom, and Ammon were nations surrounding ancient Israel and Judah.

Daniel 11:45

The glorious holy mountain includes Zion, Jerusalem, and the Temple—the place God chose for his name to dwell. • The sea probably refers to the Mediterranean Sea.

Daniel 12:1

Michael was Israel's patron angel (cp. [10:13](#), [21](#); [Rev 2:1](#), [8](#), [12](#)). • the book: This is possibly the Book of Truth ([Dan 10:21](#); cp. [7:10](#)). • will be rescued: All previous rescues of God's people in Daniel (e.g., [3:28](#); [6:27](#)) had foreshadowed, and now culminated in, the resurrection from the dead ([12:2–3](#)).

Daniel 12:1–7

At that time, the time of the end, God will rescue his people and defeat every enemy—even death.

Daniel 12:2

Everlasting life is completely without shame or disgrace (cp. [Gen 2:25](#); [3:7](#)).

Daniel 12:3

Those who are wise know their God (cp. [1:4](#), [17](#); [8:25](#); [9:22](#), [25](#); [11:32–35](#); [12:10](#)). • To shine is a familiar metaphor for life, purity, righteousness, and glory.

Daniel 12:4

Daniel was to keep the prophecy a secret (cp. [7:28](#); [8:26](#)); it would be unveiled at God's proper time, the time of the end.

Daniel 12:5

The river was the Tigris River ([10:4](#)). • The two others witnessed to God's promises (see [Num 35:30](#); [Deut 19:15](#)).

Daniel 12:7

time, times, and half a time: God appoints times for all things as he rules the flow of earthly and heavenly events (see study note on [7:24–25](#)). • The shattering of the holy people was part of God's purpose to purify them ([12:10](#)).

Daniel 12:8–10

God withheld exactly how and when all this would finally end. Daniel would not see the end ([12:13](#)); his job was to finish out his life in faith. • purified, cleansed, and refined: God would use violent and terrifying times to improve the moral and religious character of his people (cp. [11:35](#)). • Being wise includes having insight into God's ways and walking accordingly. The wicked will not understand or change their wickedness even if the vision is explained to them.

Daniel 12:11-12

the sacrilegious object that causes desecration: See [8:13-14](#), [23-26](#); [11:29-35](#). See also study note on 9:27. • God's people must wait and remain faithful when the events of the end come. • 1,290 days . . . 1,335 days: Some interpreters see these numbers as relating to specific events in the reign of Antiochus IV Epiphanes. Others see them as purely symbolic. The number 1,290 equals 43 lunar months of 30 days each, which is approximately 3½ years in the solar calendar. This might represent the final half of the final "set of seven" ([9:27](#)). The number 1,335 might represent simply an extra 45 days of waiting until the end. Those who endure the whole time, and then some, will see God act on behalf of his people.

Daniel 12:13

Daniel died before the final end, but he knew that he would rise again! Here, the end refers to that time when even the dead rise ([12:1-3](#)) and the everlasting Kingdom of God Most High is established.